

Amendment 'A Safe Bet' Ethics Application

As per our comment, please see the requested amendments to the "A Safe Bet" project.

Amendment 1: Changes to Quantitative Data Collection Period

Under the original application, we stated that the quantitative part of the study would last a period of 6 months. However, 6 months only accounts for the active data collection period with the live POC RG framework. As such, we provided an amended overview to encompass the phased timeline.

1. **POC Preparation Data Collection:** One month prior to the launch of the POC RG framework live on the gambling interface, we will begin to collect player behavioral tracking data. This is required to accurately assess and provide the initial risk-level assignment for RG tool recommendations at the start of the study period (i.e., average of the previous 30 calendar days). This month extends the study period by one month before the POC commences (i.e., October 1st to start on November 1st).
2. **POC Data Collection Period (unchanged):** On November 1st POC RG framework will go live and run for a period of 6 months as previously specified.
3. **Extended Data Collection for BETA Baseline Evaluation:** As mentioned in the original application, the POC dataset will further serve as the baseline period required for the full-scale impact evaluation of the BETA version of the RG framework. To achieve a good quality dataset, after the conclusion of the POC study period, the RG framework will remain active for an additional 3 months on the participants' accounts. The data from these three months will be combined with the POC dataset to serve as the 9-month baseline period for the BETA evaluation.
4. **Total Duration:** The data collection period is 10 months; 1 month for baseline data collection for the first POC risk assignment, 6 months for the POC, and an additional 3 months for extended data collection aimed at preparing for the BETA phase.

NB. This amendment aligns with our initial application, where it was indicated that the POC is Phase 1 and a subsequent Phase 2 will follow. We are now in the process of preparing the ethics application for the BETA phase. However, we felt that an amendment of the current application was necessary for ethical considerations and to provide a foundational structure for the upcoming BETA impact evaluation.

Amendment 2: Changes to the Participant Inclusion Threshold

In our initial ethics application, we stated that participants must have at least 15 active gambling days (AGD) in the prior period for accurate risk assessment. Due to operational constraints, this has been **updated to a minimum of 20 AGD**. This adjustment not only aligns with the technical constraints of the risk assessment algorithm but also strengthens the safety measures, ensuring a more reliable risk-level assignment for participants.

Amendment 3: Changes in Participant Consent Procedures

After consultation with the privacy officers of the collaborating gambling operators in both the United Kingdom and the Netherlands and in coordination with the ESSB Privacy Officer, we ask to amend our participant consent procedures only for the quantitative part of the study.

Rationale for Amendment:

1. **Operator Privacy Policies (informing players):** EUR is not collecting the data from the players, the operators do. Hence, both the UK and NL operators' privacy statement explains clearly that the operators need to collect data to comply with their legal obligations (UK and Dutch online gambling regulations). Additionally, the privacy statements include provisions for sharing anonymised and/or personal data with third parties for research and development purposes. As a result, players have been informed about the data collection and sharing thereof and agreed to these conditions by signing up to and using the operator's services. Further information will be provided to the players with the release of the new user interface including the POC RG framework (introduced by both operators).
2. **Receiving anonymous data:** All data transferred to the EUR is extensively anonymised (for the EUR) by the operators. The operators will not share details through which the EUR can identify the individual players. This adheres to privacy regulations and safeguards participant confidentiality.
3. **Data Privacy Officer Collaboration:** The data collection and transfer procedures, including this amendment, have been drafted in collaboration with the ESSB Privacy Officer, ensuring full compliance with relevant privacy laws.

Impact of Changes:

1. **Informed Consent:** Given that players have already been informed and agreed to collection and sharing of their data for research purposes via the operators' privacy statements and that all transferred data will be extensively anonymised, we have determined that obtaining explicit informed consent (i.e., the previous "opt-out" option) is not necessary for the quantitative part of this research. By registering on the operator's website and agreeing to operator's privacy policy and terms of use, players already consent to participate in the evaluation and monitoring of responsible gambling measures and to share their data to third parties.
2. **Notification Changes:** The operators will still notify the players about the release of the new interface, their updated responsible gambling policy, and the data sharing. The notification will be in the form of a pop-up message, which all players will see upon their next login to the operators' site. They will not have an option to opt out of this specific research initiative.
3. **Removal of Exit:** The pop-up notification will not include an "exit" icon but will include an "OKAY" button asking for players confirmation that they have read and understood the notification message. This ensures that players acknowledge the information to continue using the platform and the use of their data for scientific purposes, in line with the operators' existing terms and privacy policies.
4. **Data Privacy:** The responsibility for data use and privacy conditions continues to lie with the operators up until the sharing of the data (operators are effectively data controllers). Once data is shared with EUR, the EUR is responsible for data use and privacy conditions (EUR becomes data controller only upon receiving the data).

5. **Transparency and Accessibility of Information:** Besides the pop-up notification, information on the research aims will be available to players anytime through the dedicated, responsible gambling homepage on both UK and NL sites.

NB. In support of the amendments to participant consent procedures, we have uploaded two documents: 1) An updated version of the pop-up notification when gamblers receive the POC user interface; and 2) a data flow document crafted by (Bo Schijven), ESSB Privacy Officer, providing a comprehensive and visual representation of the data flow specific to the POC phase of the study.

Amendment 4: Changes to Sample Size and Recruitment Procedures

Our initial ethics application stipulated a desired sample size of 200,000 players, assuming a full-scale launch across both operators. In a scenario where this wasn't feasible, a random sample of 30,000 players was intended as an alternative.

Due to constraints and further insights into the operator customer base, we've revised the sampling strategy for the POC phase. In the initial phase of the POC we're employing a stratified sampling method that includes about ~8,000 players per operator for a total of ~24,000. These players are sampled within each operator customer base based on risk-level proportions: high-risk, 10% of the individual operator sample (approximately 800 players); moderate-risk, constituting 35% (around 2,800 players); and low-risk, making up the remaining and largest proportion at 55% (about 4,400 players). All gamblers in this initial sample must meet the criterion of 20 Active Gambling Days (20AGD) on the first day of POC data collection. The goal is to ensure this sample is representative of the larger player base, which includes 100,000-120,000 gamblers per operator. We have intentionally oversampled high-risk and medium-risk players to gather more data from these important segments. This stratified approach aims to create a balanced and representative initial dataset for evaluating RG framework across different risk profiles.

In addition to our initial stratified sample, we're amending the initial sampling method to include a rolling recruitment strategy as the POC progresses to account for player attrition during the 9 months of data collection, which can affect data quality for both the POC and Beta evaluations. As players "drop out"—defined as those accumulating fewer than 20 Active Gambling Days within a 90-day evaluation period—we will replenish the sample at the 90- and 180-day marks using the same stratified risk categories and 20 AGD inclusion criterion: 10% high-risk, 35% medium-risk, and 55% low-risk. Both the initial sample and the newly recruited players will be tagged at entry for identification and future analysis. Gamblers defined as "drop-outs" are not excluded from the POC study but are tagged as such. Their re-engagement with the gambling platform will be monitored, and their data will be retained if they meet the study criteria at a later stage. Additionally, new participants entering the POC study receive the same pop-up notification informing them of the user interface release and how their data will be used.